politics because of idealism. They all suffered the same things I did. So I found solace in their companionship. We could see that there were some who were in the Yatra and in politics for all the wrong reasons. They were trying to behave like watchmen around senior leaders—they were bossing us around, behaving as if they knew everything and sycophantically crowding leaders for gifts and future rewards. But 90 per cent of us saw through these and laughed it off. We were united behind our leader Rahul Gandhi, who was inspiring us with his sacrifice, idealism and discipline. He was someone we all aspired to emulate, and he sharpened our commitment.

Like Mahatma Gandhi, Rahul Gandhi became the symbol of resistance. All credit must go to him for his determination, dedication and commitment. I don’t know if he realizes this, but he forced the Congress party to reconnect with India and the Indian people. At most, each of us would have connected to our own district or our respective states. But he made us meet people across the length and breadth of India. He gave us a political education that no other leader would have. I have such a deeper appreciation of local artisans, ancient practices and traditional cuisines (my favourite) from across India. And he showed us all that politics is more than climbing this slippery pole. His historic odyssey, which is now our historic odyssey, firmly reasserted that politics revolves around our people, their dreams and their aspirations. And it indelibly stamped one thing on all our minds: Our only duty is to empower people to become the architects of their fate. Because of that, I felt that the Yatra was both a political and a cultural renaissance that trained us to forge a stronger, more inclusive nation.